

PHILOSOPHY 354: METAPHYSICS
FINAL EXAM
ADALIDA BACA

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PART I: DEFINITIONS (42 potential points)

1. **Substance (Aristotle)** – Primary substance is a subject that cannot be predicated nor contained within itself. For instance, I am a subject, and I cannot say of something else that it is Adalida because it would be universalizing a subject that is a particular. A secondary substance is however universal and can be predicated of a subject because it is a kind or genus of a substance. I also cannot say what makes up Adalida is Adalida. This is significant for Aristotle because substance is the only category in which his other categories are built upon and is later used for his hylomorphism concept.
2. **Matter (Aristotle)** – Matter, for Aristotle, is that which a thing is made from. For instance, a table is made from wood and this wood undergoes a change to become a table. Therefore, matter is what makes up a thing and stays constant while undergoing change. This is significant for Aristotle because matter alone is not what makes up a natural being. Instead it is the combination of matter and form that make up a substance. Therefore, Aristotle needs to make the distinction between form and matter in order to illustrate how they come together in his hylomorphism concept.
3. **Essence (Aristotle)** - Essence, for Aristotle, is the “what it is to be that the thing” for an object. In other words, essence for an object is its “thisness”. For example, an object, like a cup, has a “thisness”, which is to drink from. The same way a comb has a thisness of combing. This is significant for Aristotle because essence is the basis for any substance. A substance cannot be without an essence or a “thisness”. The same way a cup cannot be without a “thisness” because it’s “thisness” is an underlying account of its own nature. In essence, essence explains the nature of a substance.
4. **Potency (Feser)** - Potency is the potential for a thing to be. In other words, potency is the possibility of becoming for something. Feser uses the term *being-in-potency* to describe potency and he does so using the example of a round ball. A round ball has the potential to be flat and squishy even if it is not actually flat and squishy. The significance of this is that being-in-potency acts as a middle ground between actuality and nothingness. Something is not nothing instead, it is still potential.
10. **Affect (Spinoza)** – Affect for Spinoza refers to states of the mind and body that are associated with feelings and emotion. Spinoza has three main types of affects and they are pleasure or joy, pain or sorrow, desire or appetite. To illustrate, when my body is sick, it takes on an affect of pain. This is significant because affects are states of a body in relation to

the world around it. Therefore, these states are crucial for beings because they help guide them towards or away from something or action.



PART II: COMPARATIVE SHORT ANSWERS (60 potential points)

Section A: Aristotle and Feser/ Scholasticism

Explain the notion of “hylomorphism,” as this is developed in Aristotle and Scholasticism. What is “hylomorphism?” In what ways do the Scholastics build upon Aristotle’s hylemorphic metaphysics? Are the Scholastics more decisive than Aristotle in their versions of hylomorphism in any way? Are there any notable differences between them?

Hylomorphism, originally developed by Aristotle, is the concept that being consists of matter and form. Where matter is that which a thing is made from and form is the transformation of that matter into something else. Aristotle couples this concept with living things to show that the soul is related to the body the same way form is to matter. He does so by showing that the soul makes a living thing alive, which makes it a cause or principle of a living thing.

The Scholastics build upon Aristotle’s hylomorphism by following Aristotle’s concept that a living being’s soul is its form but added that it was only a being’s substantial form. A substantial form is a form which organizes matter in order to make it understandable. In other words, the soul configures the body to give it life.

Section B: Aristotle and Spinoza

How would Aristotle and Spinoza each view the metaphysical status of mathematical objects, such as numbers? (How) is each able to account for mathematical truth within their respective systems? How are they similar to, and how are they different from one another?

Both Spinoza and Aristotle used mathematics in their reasoning. Therefore, at the very least, both of these philosophers view numbers and mathematical objects as having value in terms of philosophical reasoning.

However, Spinoza likely would have seen these things as parts of human imagination - consistent and correct in and of themselves, but subject to human error. While the mathematics we dream up may be useful within its own domain, it may have no bearing at all on reality. Aristotle used algebra and geometry to understand real-world objects, but also somewhat disconnected it with reality. He certainly wouldn't see them as hylomorphic as they don't have both matter and form.

Spinoza discusses numbers directly and states that we may see them as separate parts in our imagination, but really they are all one. So all of mathematics is really part of one substance of which each object is a part! Aristotle sees numbers as being formal causes of other things - they tend to lie somewhere between "sensible things" and Forms.

Aristotle would likely have placed numbers and mathematical objects in a category of their own - he discusses them at length in his Metaphysics but doesn't really settle into a definition. Spinoza may have also classified them as symbols - which he calls a certain kind of knowledge (imagination).

Aristotle and Spinoza seem to agree that mathematical objects are not tangible things nor substances. They both see the value in their use. However, they don't seem to agree on exactly what they are. Aristotle tends to use them as an extension of form, while Spinoza sees them as being part of the imagination. Also, Aristotle briefly entertains the idea that mathematical objects are substances, but seems to eventually side with the idea that Ideas are substances, and numbers and other mathematical objects are distinct from this.

Section C: Aristotle and Heidegger

How does Aristotle view the nature and purpose of logic in relation to metaphysics? How does this differ from the way in which Heidegger views logic? In what way does logic “determine” Being or beings for each thinker?

For Aristotle, the nature and purpose of logic in relation to metaphysics is that logic is that which provides a system for investigating good and bad reasoning. This system is what Aristotle would call first philosophy because it examines the general and first principles of science. These first principles must coincide with the laws of logic because if they did not, they would not make sense. For instance, Aristotle uses the principle of non-contradiction to show this by illustrating that it could be the case for both p and not p to be true. Therefore, logic in relation to metaphysics is as a system for investigating reason.

This differs from Heidegger who views logic is grounded in Metaphysics.

Section D: Feser/ Scholasticism and Spinoza

How do the Scholastics and Spinoza differ in their views on causation? How does each system conceive of the nature of causation (e.g., its definition, qualities, and/ or types)? How do they view the scope of causation (i.e., whether causation has any limits, and if so, what they are)? How do their views on causation determine each system's views on freedom?

Spinoza's causation is quite tightly coupled with his concept of substance monism - that there is only one substance and that substance is God. Spinoza's causation is a condition of necessity, if something occurs it must occur. More specifically, if a substance exists, it must exist. This is often called self-causation. On the corollary, if a substance does not exist, it must not exist and causes itself not to exist.

On the other hand, Scholastic causation is much more punctuated - there are many causes and effects, and in the "paradigmatic" case, these occur simultaneously. Furthermore, a cause can have a finite duration, an example being a heater warming a room. Causes are therefore more immediate - the problem of the prime mover is averted by looking only at the "immediate" cause, rather than having to chase a big chain back to the origin of everything.

Spinoza asserts that substances are causally independent, one substance cannot cause another, they are only caused on their own account. Feser states that to be a substance, something must have both properties and causal powers - clearly implying that substances can cause effects on other substances.

Spinoza's causation is more closely aligned with the formal and final causes, causation implies existence. Scholastic causation is more closely aligned with the efficient and final causes, which are how we typically view causation in everyday life. Spinoza uses causation as a tool to examine differences between substance and the nature of our world and God, while Scholastics use causation to understand everyday experiences.

Scholasticism draws a clear delineation between the principle of sufficient reason and the principle of causality. Spinoza instead relies implicitly on the principle of sufficient reason to come to his formulation of causation. When working to agree with the principle of sufficient reason, Feser states that the rationalist interpretation of the principle of sufficient reason is false, using an example that the conjunction of all true logical statements cannot be explained by another true logical statement. He instead offers an alternative explanation which supports the principle of causation.

Section E: Feser/ Scholasticism and Heidegger

Explain what the “analogy of Being” is according to Aquinas, what the philosophical motivations for introducing it into metaphysics were, and how it was objected to by other Scholastics. How would Heidegger view this notion of the “analogy of Being?” Is this something he would find to have philosophical value? Why or why not?

First, we must understand the word "analogy" as used here. Analogy is the "middle-ground" between univocal and equivocal meanings - the same and distinct meanings. An analogous meaning is related to the first meaning but different. The analogy of Being is most useful when applied to act and potency. An act has being in the obvious sense of the word. Potency has being in an analogous sense - a similar and related but distinct type of being.

This analogy of Being would only have value to Heidegger as a distinct, unequivocal sort of being. Heidegger's being is closely related to "Dasein", which is a type of being that humans experience. In particular, nothing has being unless it is capable of making sense of the world around it. Therefore, not only does potency not have being in this sense, but not everything called "act" has being.

The analogy of Being according to Aquinas is therefore orthogonal to Heidegger's concept of being. Given this, there is certainly value in bridging this philosophical gap. However, this type of analysis is best left to Heidegger's contemporaries and successors. It is unlikely he himself would have liked to attempt to reconcile these notions. The reason for this is he goes to great lengths to examine and define what Being really is. Getting to muddy this up with analogous language could only serve to muddy the clarity and specificity he gives to the term.

While the analogy of Being according Aquinas is often used as a metaphysical metaphor to use the relationship between act and potency to describe the relationship between God and the world, Heidegger analyzes Being specifically as being-in-the world. Therefore, the analogy of Being, in its typical use, lies outside the realm in which Heidegger uses Being.

Perhaps one use Heidegger could make of this analogy is to understand the condition that a human comes into - Befindlichkeit. This has Being in a similar way that potency has being, not existing in the obvious sense that we can perceive in Dasein, but says something about Dasein itself.

Section F: Spinoza and Heidegger

How do Spinoza and Heidegger differ in their conceptions of the essence of the human? What possibilities, qualities, and/or activities of the human does each highlight? What does each see as the fulfillment of the human essence? Are their differing views of the human essence compatible, or are they inconsistent?

One key difference is the concept that Spinoza sees the human as being largely tied to the characteristics of the body, while Heidegger largely regards the things that transcend the body to be what makes humans unique. Heidegger sees humans as unique because they understand Being, and lead their own lives. Spinoza instead highlights that the true nature of being is concealed from humans and is privy only to God, and that humans tend to thrust their own passions upon God.

According to Spinoza, human power is extremely limited, and external aids can really only serve to help us preserve the body. For Heidegger, fulfillment occurs during Dasein - while death ends Dasein it does not imply that anything was fulfilled. Heidegger remarks about Care as part of Dasein, and understanding of our nature as part of our essential functions.

The differing views are compatible but also are analogous, Heidegger and Spinoza don't see the human as being the same thing. While Spinoza focuses on the particular experience of the human, Heidegger distinguishes our existence as the ability to analyze our own existence and the world in which we find ourselves. This is a bit more general of an approach - we could be an entirely different kind of animal but the same Dasein.

These concepts are compatible insofar as we accept that they do not describe exactly the same thing. If we consider "human existence" to be a univocal term, then they are incompatible. Spinoza draws too many distinctions between the human and divine experience, where for Heidegger this line is much blurrier. Nothing would prohibit a deity of any sort from having a human-like essence in the Heideggerian sense.

According to Spinoza, the human mind is part of the infinite intellect of God. Heidegger's Dasein is a particular mode of being experienced to human beings, and is not necessarily part of what God experiences. We could be entirely independent, and not part of a larger whole.